

SSA Starter Kit

Steps to Guide Your Application

This starter kit walks you step by step through applying for Social Security (SSA) benefits — for your **child (ages 0-17)** or for an **adult (18+)**. Follow the steps in order, and keep this kit nearby while you apply.

STEP 1 — CREATE YOUR ID.ME ACCOUNT

ID.me is a free, secure account that proves who you are online. Social Security uses it to let you sign in safely at **ssa.gov**.

What you need before you start:

- An **email address** you can open right away — your sign-in codes are sent there
- A **cell phone** — ID.me texts or calls you a code to prove it is really you
- A **government photo ID** — a driver's license, state ID card, or passport
- Your **Social Security number**
- Good light and a few quiet minutes — you may be asked to take a photo of your ID and a selfie so ID.me can match your face to your ID card

Applying for a child (ages 0-17): the **parent or legal guardian** creates the ID.me account — in the **parent's own name**, with the **parent's own photo ID**. You prove your identity, and then you enter your child's information in the application. A child does not get their own ID.me or my Social Security account.

Applying for an adult (18+): the **adult** creates their **own** ID.me account, with their **own photo ID** and their own information. A parent or family member can sit with them and help, but the account, the ID, and the selfie must be the adult's own.

When your ID.me account is ready, use it to sign in to **my Social Security** at **ssa.gov**, and make sure you can log in before you move on.

STEP 2 — QUESTIONNAIRE & GATHER YOUR DOCUMENTS

Once your ID.me is done, you are ready for the **questionnaire** and for **gathering your documents**. The questionnaire is the list of questions in Step 3 below — write your answers down first, so applying online is calm and fast.

Gather these documents:

- Certified **birth certificate** and **Social Security card** (child or adult applying)
- **Photo ID** — for the adult applying, or the parent applying for a child
- Insurance cards (health insurance, Medicaid, CHIP)
- A list of all **medical conditions** and when each was diagnosed
- A list of all **medications** — name, dose, and the doctor who prescribed each one

- A list of all **medical providers** — doctors, clinics, hospitals, therapists — with addresses and phone numbers
- **Medical records** — ask your providers for copies of records and test results
- For a child: **school records** — the latest IEP, FIE, or ARD, and recent report cards
- For an adult: **work history** information — employers and dates for the last 15 years
- **Bank information** for direct deposit — bank name, routing number, and account number

Keep them safe: take clear photos or scans of your documents and **upload them into one secure folder** on your computer or phone. Give the folder a clear name, like “SSA Application.” Keep the paper copies together in the same order. Having everything in one folder makes the application — and your phone interview later — much easier.

STEP 3 — APPLY ONLINE

With your documents gathered, go to **ssa.gov**, sign in with your ID.me, and start the application. **Answer all the questions asked on the application** — do not leave answers blank. If you do not know an answer, use your notes from Step 2.

Here is what the application will ask you:

- **Applying for benefits** — which benefit you are applying for (SSI, SSDI, or DAC — Disabled Adult Child benefits for an adult whose disability began before age 22)
- **Identity verification** — full legal name, date of birth, Social Security number, address, phone, and email
- **Medical conditions** — every condition, when it was diagnosed, and how it affects daily life and work
- **Medications** — name, dosage, how often it is taken, and who prescribed it
- **Medical providers** — every doctor, clinic, hospital, and therapist, with addresses, phone numbers, and dates seen
- **If you have applied for benefits before** — when you applied, and what Social Security decided
- **Work history** — for an adult, jobs from the last 15 years (job title, employer, dates, duties); for a child, SSA asks about the parents’ work and income instead
- **Education and training** — highest grade completed, GED, special education or IEP, and any vocational training or certifications
- **Direct deposit** — your bank name, routing number, and account number, so benefits can be paid to your account

For a child (0-17): the parent or guardian fills out the application with the **child’s** medical and school information, plus the **parents’** income and living situation, because SSI for a child looks at the household.

For an adult (18+): the adult’s own medical history, work history, education, and income are used. A parent or helper can sit with the adult while they answer.

STEP 4 — SAVE YOUR REFERENCE NUMBER

When you finish the application, Social Security gives you a **Reference #** (your confirmation/re-entry number). **Always save your Reference #** — write it down, take a photo of the screen, and keep it in your secure folder with your documents. You will need this number to return to your application, check its status, or if you have to call SSA about it. **Do not lose it.**

STEP 5 — BE PATIENT: YOUR PHONE INTERVIEW

You are done applying — now **be patient**. Social Security will send you a **notice for a phone interview** (it can come by email or by mail). Write down the date and time when the notice arrives, keep your secure folder next to you for the call, and make sure you answer the phone — the call may come from a number you do not know.

Questions at any step? Email Southern Oak at **supporthelpsofw@gmail.com** — we are here to guide you.

PLEASE READ — IMPORTANT INFORMATION

Southern Oak Financial & Wellness provides education, guidance, and application support. We are **not legal attorneys** and do not provide legal advice. We do **not** guarantee approval of any Social Security application — only the Social Security Administration (SSA) decides who is approved. All Southern Oak sales are final — **no refunds**. This kit is for the buyer's personal use only. Please do not copy or share it.

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